



BEFORE

From its founding in 1818, the American Colonization Society strove to send freed slaves and free Black people in the North to foreign shores, in particular Liberia.

COLONIZATION

It was believed, not only by enslavers, but also by some abolitionists, that Black and white people could not coexist in the United States. The only successful colony was **Liberia** in West Africa, which became an independent state in 1847. **Lincoln** himself was a known **proponent of colonization** before issuing the [Emancipation Proclamation](#) and supported several schemes during the war, most of which ended in tragedy for the emigrants.

RIGHTS IN THE NORTH

Before the war, only **Massachusetts** legally extended **full voting rights** to its **Black citizens**. Some other **New England** states allowed **Black male suffrage**, and in New York those with **\$250 worth of property** could vote. To have a vote in Ohio, over half a citizen's ancestry had to be white. No other state allowed Black people to vote.

During the war, some **gains were made in civil rights**. Black Americans could ride alongside whites in Philadelphia and Washington streetcars, and in 1864 they were allowed to appear as both **witnesses and lawyers in federal courts**, but further reforms would have to wait for the **14th Amendment** (see [The Politics of Reconstruction](#) and [The Reality of Black Freedom](#)).